

Bob Ingram

'As I Was Saying ...'

Two Power Men

NOBODY could hit a baseball any farther than Bill Pinckard and Arlo Engel, former El Paso players, could hit one.

Engel and Pinckard hit some prodigious clouts at Dudley Field and elsewhere in the league competition.

Pinckard played in the Arizona-Texas League days. Engel came later when the El Paso club was in the Texas League. He was brought here by the San Francisco Giants. "He has Ruthian power," said George Genovese, the manager of the Sun Kings. He wasn't exaggerating one bit.

It was in an era before the tape measure homers. Arlo hit the ball far in the night and far out of Dudley Field on a number of occasions. They qualified for tape measures.

Arlo led the Texas League in homers one season.

Pinckard played only a season here. He had some herculian swats at Dudley Field. He played for Andy Cohen one year with Denver in the old Western League. Chet Nelson of the Rocky Mountain News recalls him hitting some drives of 475 and 500 feet. He had 35 homers.

Pitcher's Patsy

THE BIG TROUBLE with both Pinckard and Engel was that neither could make contact with the ball often enough.

After Engel's one-year homer achievement, it was like a falling barometer. His average went down and down. I saw him strike out four and five times a game. There were not isolated cases either. He did it quite often. Opposing pitchers looked forward to seeing him come up to the plate.

The Giants naturally didn't give up easily on a batter of his power. They gave him special instruction in hitting. They finally saw it was useless. They let him go. Other clubs picked him up. They had their best batting coaches teach him. Engel was an enthusiastic pupil. He did a lot of experimenting and work on his swing.

"I've got it now," he would say optimistically. Then he'd get back in the old rut of striking out.

He finally had to give up baseball and is living on the West Coast now.

Nabs Bank Robber

PINCKARD MADE a little more contact than Arlo but not a great deal more. He had that year in the Western League.

It was his last in organized ball. He played two years in Japan and then retired from the game.

He was a Hollywood stunt man for awhile.

Now he owns a sporting goods business in San Fernando Valley in California and sells products that include Japanese baseballs and Japanese bamboo bats.

Last January, Pinckard walked into a Bank of America in Canoga Park, Calif., and heard a teller shout, "bank robber."

As fast as he used to bring his bat off his shoulder, Pinckard grabbed the hoodlum and disarmed him. He got a special commendation from the FBI for his action.

Archie Templeton, a southpaw pitcher who played for Albuquerque in the old Arizona-Texas League, was just as big a case of frustration as were Engel and Pinckard.

Templeton could throw the ball as fast as Bob Feller or Walter Johnson.

But he had so much trouble finding the plate that his career ended before he got out of the bushes. In the old A-T, he held all kinds of strikeout records. But if he had close to 20 strikeouts in a game, he would have the same number of walks.

One little but highly important deficiency kept Pinckard, Engel and Templeton out of the big leagues and possibly super star status. About all that one can say is, "too bad."